

# 1916-29

## THE JAZZ AGE

**The decade** after the end of World War I is sometimes called the “Jazz Age”, or the “Roaring Twenties”. It was a period of huge social and cultural change when young people, freed from the troubles of conflict, turned to leisure and enjoyment, adopting new fashions, dances, and music – most particularly jazz. Originating in New Orleans, jazz culture became popular in the US, with London, Paris, Singapore, and other cities following suit. Social restrictions relaxed and a buoyant sense of freedom spread. Women in particular embraced the new era, following increases in social freedoms during World War I and as a result of the suffrage movement. Now they shrugged off old stereotypes of dependency and frailty

in favour of independence, public involvement, and sexual freedom. The “new woman” appeared; wearing short skirts, with bobbed hair, and smoking cigarettes, she rejected convention.

In the US, the Jazz Age coincided with prohibition – a nationwide ban on alcohol – and young people flocked to speakeasies and dance halls to drink illegal liquor, allowing gangsters such as Al Capone to make huge profits from bootleg alcohol. Popular entertainment also boomed, fuelled by technological developments in recording, cinema, and radio. The Jazz Age was brought to an end in 1929, when the Wall Street crash heralded a decade of economic depression.



### KEY MOMENTS

#### 1916-17 Jazz moves north

Poor economic conditions and discrimination prompted the migration of millions of African Americans from the rural south. Over the following years, musicians such as Louis Armstrong (*left*) brought jazz to Chicago and New York, then to Paris and London.

#### 1918 Harlem Renaissance

From around 1918, Harlem, Manhattan was a focal point of Black American culture. Through literature, music, theatre, and dance, poets such as Langston Hughes and entertainers such as Josephine Baker (*left*) brought Black culture into public consciousness.

#### 1925 The Great Gatsby

With their fast-paced lifestyle, Scott Fitzgerald and his wife Zelda (*left*) epitomized the spirit of the age. Fitzgerald's novel *The Great Gatsby* (1925) portrayed the flamboyance as well as the brittleness of the Jazz Age.

